

The trouble is they don't believe that their code can actually hurt anyone, which is the mind frame of most teenagers anyways. Some do it out of personal curiosity, to prove a point; others do it to impress their peers, while still others do it to enter the underground computing communities. These communities often consider virus writers as the bottom of their hierarchy and place hackers at the top.

Virus writers represent the wild, unpredictable younger siblings whose unleashed programs are uncontrollable. Hacking on the other hand involves different and more refined skills. A hacker tends to target a specific computing system and make a surgical strike. While hacking is all about gaining control, virus writing is all about uncontrolled mayhem.

Like any adolescent, virus writers tend to mature and change their ways. Most quit the activity once they understand the ramifications of a virus unleashed. Ten years back, virus writers fell in the 14 to 17 year old bracket, while today they're 25 to 28. Women have been known to write viruses. Like all things social, it is difficult to define the mind of a virus writer.

These days the Internet makes it easy to share source code. In the early days of the boot sector viruses, writers needed a certain level of programming skills. Things only got simpler and easier. What's more, virus writers show off their source code at Web sites and distribute the kits we have covered above. Anybody with the inclination can now create a virus.

Society also sends across mixed signals to potential virus creators. While the law seeks to throw them behind bars, security companies have been known to either hire them as consultants or as part of their workforce. Even the press paints them as code cowboys, wild men who live on the edge and dangerously. The attraction is obvious.

So what's the motivation? Malicious intent, honing software skills, exploiting vulnerabilities, experiments, revenge, hobby, peer acceptance, pride... The reasons are as varied as the viruses.